

EDUCATION

Mandarin is finding fans in schools, writes Madeleine Heffernan.

Mandarin has become the most studied language among state school students for the first time, thanks to a surge of Chinese study at primary schools across Victoria.

Mandarin now accounts for 18.8 per cent of total language enrolments, with more than 82,000 students enrolled in Chinese at state primary and secondary schools and the Victorian School of Languages last year. The VSL offers out-of-school-hours and distance education programs to students who cannot access their language of choice in their school.

A new report by the Victorian Department of Education shows more languages programs in primary schools and more students taking languages to year 12 level.

In total, students in Victoria studied 70 languages through government schools, the VSL and community language schools in 2018. Indonesian was taught by the highest number of schools, followed by Japanese, Mandarin, Italian and French.

"If we look at today's student population, even the monolingual Anglophone students are not as monolingual as they think," said Michiko Weinmann, senior lecturer in education at Deakin University. "Our students are becoming I think increasingly global."

The report also shows the rise of AUSLAN to the sixth most-studied language and an increase in the number of students studying Aboriginal languages.

Enrolments in Mandarin study among state school students have more than tripled since 2011, the year it first became a top-five language among state school students. The vast majority of Mandarin students last year were in primary school, the figures show.

Academic Yvette Slaughter, who helped with the report, said schools that had not offered a foreign language until recent years were choosing Chinese.

"One of the reasons why Chinese has gone up at the primary school is because the study of languages in Victorian schools is a legislative requirement; it's one of the eight key learning areas. That has never been enforced until the last five years or so," Dr Slaughter said.

Found in translation



Box Hill High School offers Mandarin and German for students as part of its languages program. Photo: Eddie Jim

"Schools that don't have programs tended to be in regional clusters... so [these] schools have been working as clusters to agree to teach the same language and employ the same teacher and that accounts in part for the large surge in Chinese at the primary level."

Dr Slaughter, language and literacy lecturer at the Melbourne Graduate School of Education, said Chinese had started from a much lower base than other languages, partly because there were too few qualified teachers.

While Mandarin was easily the most studied language in state primary schools, more students

studied French, Japanese, Italian and Indonesian at secondary level.

"French, Indonesian, Italian and Japanese have always traditionally done better [in enrolment numbers]. They're not declining enrolments so the rise in Chinese is not at the expense of the other languages. But the schools that are picking up languages are picking up Chinese," she said.

It is unclear whether independent and Catholic schools would have similar trends to government schools, which educate about two-thirds of Victorian students. Independent Schools Victoria said it did not have similar data.

Catholic Education Melbourne did not respond. Catholic schools have traditionally offered Indonesian and Italian, said Dr Weinmann.

Mandarin is the most spoken language other than English in Australia, and China is Australia's biggest trading partner.

"It is a community language but China is one of our major trading partners, [and] there's a strong engagement particularly in private schools that students do Chinese as a language," said Ruth Arber, a senior lecturer in education at Deakin University.

Dr Slaughter said the question was how strong demand for Chinese at a primary level translated into the secondary level.

"People do think of it as really hard; I struggle when I try to learn a bit of Chinese. But I think given how hard it is for a second-language learner to learn Chinese, it's really great there are some kids who are going to be proficient when they finish high school."

Box Hill High School, a high-performing school in a suburb where almost 80 per cent of residents were born in China, offers Mandarin and German.

Principal Losh Pillay said Mandarin had always been popular,

and the school offered three streams as students proceeded to the senior levels: Chinese first language, Chinese first language advanced, and Chinese second language.

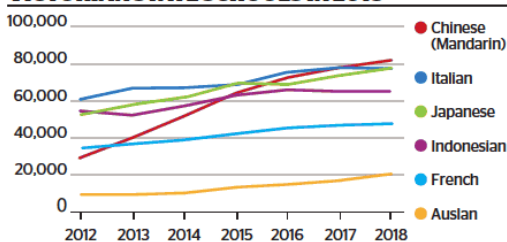
"In VCE we probably have two, sometimes three classes as they hit year 12, which is still fairly healthy," she said.

The report shows strong take-up of language among Victorian year 12 students. Last year, 19.4 of state school graduates studied a language. Further, 21.7 per cent of students across state, Catholic and independent schools finished with a language – a really high figure for an Anglophone country, Dr Slaughter said.

Victorian Education Minister James Merlino said: "We have a proud history of multiculturalism, with more than 250 languages spoken in Victoria. That's why it's important our schools reflect this cultural and linguistic diversity in the languages on offer."

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LANGUAGES STUDIED IN VICTORIAN STATE SCHOOLS IN 2018



VCE alternative does not give unfair advantage

COMMENT
Maxwell Yong

The ATAR conversion system does not give International Baccalaureate students an "unfair advantage". It's not unfair that 2 per cent of IB students receive perfect scores when only 0.08 per cent of VCE students do.

I chose to undertake the IB because the music subject was more inclined towards my interests and I had heard that it would better prepare me for university, not because I believed it would give me an edge over my VCE counterparts.

Recently, a perceived inequity between the two programs

prompted a change in the way IB scores are converted into ATARs, with Australian admissions centres to draw on more detailed data about IB students' performance before converting their scores into ATARs from 2021.

However, the proposed "solution" to the problem undermines the IB system, which has been successfully implemented into many countries' tertiary admissions centres.

Regardless, all this fuss simply misses the point. Why? Because no matter what VTAC does, the two systems will always be incommensurable. Apples and oranges. The two systems are so different that a comparison is

impossible, making "equity" between IB and VCE fantastical.

Now, to be giving so much criticism, I must have the groundbreaking solution, so here it is: place the onus on the universities to determine IB entry scores. Not only does this stop the need for direct comparison, it allows the universities to ascertain the value of the IB in respect to each individual course.

For example, an arts course might value the experience IB graduates gained from writing the 4000-word extended essay, so would set a lower IB entry score than a science degree that has the same ATAR admission score.

Place the onus on unis to determine IB entry scores.

This is the tried and tested method that works everywhere else in the world. All the major US, UK and south-east Asian tertiary institutions post IB results in conjunction with their local system.

While Australian universities do post IB entry scores for courses, this only applies to international applicants, meaning that domestic students have to convert their scores and subject themselves to the

ATAR requirements. Therefore, it doesn't seem like it would be difficult for universities to abolish the conversion and simply value domestic IB scores in their own right.

While I agree that the current conversion system is flawed, I reject the ill-considered fix that explicitly undermines the IB philosophy.

As an IB graduate, I implore Australian universities to adopt IB scores as a method of granting entry to domestic students.

Maxwell Yong is an IB graduate of 2018 and is now studying a Bachelor of Commerce and Diploma of Music at Melbourne University.